

VIDEOING THE CHAOS OF EVACUATION IN KHUSHWANT SINGH'S *TRAIN TO PAKISTAN*.

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ABSTRACT:

*It is not that easy task to convert a work of art into the digital filmic milieu. Hence, a lot of oeuvres that have been adapted and shifted into movies couldn't reach their splendid prestige unless being depicted well previously by theatres' specialists and movies' designers. So, it is apparent that, some literary feats already were written in short period within one year at maximum for instance but when the makers of movies went to convert them into films, such works at least took three years to be depicted into movies. Therefore, we can say that writing the work of art often is easier than transforming that work into the world of videoing. Consequently, some concepts seem so difficult to be shifted into films as they bear so tragic, melancholic, or adventurous circumstances and hence changing them into visible facts demand patently paying more endless endeavors and time. So, Khushwant Singh (1915-2014), an Indian author, politician, and journalist wrote his marvelous fiction *Train to Pakistan* in 1956 but it was adapted into the cinematic and visual world in 1998 and was directed by Pamela Rooks. The most influential aspect in the novel is that, it includes several situations and conditions for the characters and hence the videoing staff of the film with the same name " *Train to Pakistan*" suffered a lot while converting love into hatred, peace into war, coexistence into an arbitrary evacuation, and yet friendship into death. So, this article is mainly shedding light on how the concept of evacuation chaos has been already adapted from the manuscript of Singh into the film of Rooks with essential concentration on the realistic portrayal of such social tragic crisis that divided the cultural, religious, and political trends of the common people across the two countries. It ultimately asserts that, the videoing adaptation of the literary oeuvre can carry the fundamental theme in more apparent method than the written feat.*

Keywords: *Train to Pakistan*, Chaos, Partition, Evacuation, Film.

Introduction:

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Train to Pakistan (1956) is regarded as very historical and realistic Indian fiction as obviously addressing the plight of partition of the Indian subcontinent into two states namely India and Pakistan immediately after the independence from the British colonization during the mid of the twentieth century. So, it confirms how people particularly the common ones were suffering as a result of that partition that didn't happen peacefully but accompanied with many atrocities and quandaries that destroyed the dreams of more people in the two countries and hence the conditions imposed the dividing had encapsulated the social nature in both states. Thereof, the current paper is going to depict such calamity with reference to its transformation into film or videoing it especially with the appearance of the movies in the beginning of the twentieth century. However, the major case that shaped *Train to Pakistan* is explicitly represented in its treatment for the extent of partition and the surrounding circumstances like how love is going to lose its value, how family is going for endless social distancing, how religions failed to satisfy the human need, and even how lovers were forced to get rid of love and to replace it with the predicament of sacrifice. Therefore, depiction of such painful conditions was not that easy mission but rather it was created under the influential efforts of very famous actors as Nirmal Pandey, Rajit Kapur, Mohan Agashe, Smriti Mishra, Mangal Dhillon and Divya Dutta.

Khushwant Singh as very splendid political writer doesn't behave to present simple themes but in fact he seems brilliant and smart through his selection for very meaningful and valuable themes in his novelistic feats as the issue of partition is his great realistic fiction called *Train to Pakistan* (1956). The novel melancholically mentions the plight of partition on its two dimensions; the political and the social ones. However, converting it into film does need creating a similar environment to the selected village by Singh in his novel. Hence, Rooks and her fellow-actors decided to create an imaginative village including the same features (trees, poor peasants, railway station, pastoral cottages, homes of worship, pets, and two paramours).

At first, Pamela Rooks was obliged to provide and fill the established hamlet (border village) with huge crowds of common people to deal with them as those who were oppressed by the ramifications and the novel brutalities occurred during the great evacuation that is indeed one of the most heartbreaking and biggest kind of evacuation on earth. Thousands of people from both sides were forced daily to cross the borders between the two states searching meanwhile for their salvation, real identity, coexistence, social rights and economic welfare. A large number of those roaming common people had lost their life in such gloomy eradication. A lot of them were arbitrarily deprived of their own possessions, homes, and land only to achieve the colonial conceptualization that was planned for between the two countries by the British settlement which dominated the Indian subcontinent for more than four hundred years. Thus, we can re-imagine the real pictures of that mandatory evacuation as in the below four ones taking into account the keen comparison between the real and the videoed ones.

The real pictures



The adapted pictures



Khushwant Singh deftly used characters from all the castes and religions of India to reveal the nature of peace and love that were encapsulating the public life in the Indian subcontinent. He blended between the purity of rural life and the anarchy of the urban authority. Moreover, he was obsessed with depiction of the murderous turmoil that dominated the process of evacuation. Therefore, he found himself obliged to burden the makers of movies with studying carefully every single piece in his novel before being adapted into movies and the cinematic world.

Pamela Brooks and Nirmal Pandey began to search for an imaginative village to represent the Mano Majra one as found in the novel of Singh. They established a border-village naming it Mano Majra and started to crowd it with hosts of people, pets, and simple mud huts. Singh provided the village in his novel with Hindus, Muslims and Sikhs and the same conduct had been adapted by Brooks and Pandey. In the beginning of their adaptation, they created an atmosphere of love, harmony, and peace among all the people regardless of their castes, affiliations and doctrines. Such portrayal was meant by to posit the pre-partition time in which there was no enmity and murdering between people. Moreover, Singh could mix between love and pain in his novel and such endeavor was imitated by the movies makers in the film too. Singh described the communal milieu in his novelistic village positing that

Mano Majra is a tiny place. It has only three brick buildings, one of which is the home of the moneylender Lala Ram Lal. The other two

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are the Sikh temple and the mosque. The three brick buildings enclose triangular common with a large peepul tree in the middle. The rest of the village is a cluster of flat-roofed mud huts and low-walled courtyards, which front on narrow lanes that radiate from the centre. Soon the lanes dwindle into footpaths and get lost in the surrounding fields. At the western end of the village there is a pond ringed round by keekar trees. There are only about seventy families in Mano Majra, and Lala Ram Lal's is the only Hindu family. The others are Sikhs or Muslims, about equal in number. The Sikhs own all the land around the village; the Muslims are tenants and share the tilling with the owners. There are a few families of sweepers whose religion is uncertain. (10)

In light of the abovementioned description, it is evident Singh suffered less than Brooks and Pandey while guessing the environment of the village of *Train to Pakistan*. However, the essential nature of the novel is selected by Singh but creating of all the items, deciding the special attires of both the central characters and the crowded evacuees had been carefully designed by Brooks and Pandey.

Pandey and Brooks could decide the suitable uniforms for the characters on basis of their social rank and religious background. Lala Ram's family seems the only Hindu family in Mano Majra while the other seventy families dwelling on the village are of Muslim and Sikh roots almost in equal numbers. So, he appears in Hindu attire. Iqbal Singh is the social worker who is highly obsessed with converting the villagers for the new ideological concepts that came into the stage as a result of the partition and independence. Imam Baksh is the father of Nooran and both are Muslims. Pandey obviously dealt with Imam Bash as a blind man just as depicted in the manuscript of Singh. His prominence proves his goodness and humbleness as working as the mullah of the local mosque in the village. So, he looks like in Muslim dress. Malli is the villain who is accused with being a dacoit who attacked the house of Ram Lala. He is exposed in very wicked form with a dirty domestic dresses that can suggest his atrocity and demeanor as a thief. He is arrested and Pandey succeeds to convey his real picture within the jail. Moreover, Nooran is the Muslim teenager and the girlfriend of Juggut Singh who is arrested falsely as charged with dacoity against the home of Ram Lal. She feels sympathetic towards him and doesn't like to leave the village as she doesn't want to lose her love for him. She appears in veil and Indian Punjabi. There are officials in the village as Sahib, the inspector and the head constable and both are dressed officially. Thus, Brooks and Pandey tried their best to dress each of those characters his/her appropriate attire to undergo the applied role of him/her.

Mano Majra, the fictional village of Khushwant Singh's *Train to Pakistan*, seems apparently as a religiously border diverse border village and hence it is clear that Brooks provides it with temples for Hindus and Sikhs and mosque for Muslims to prove the spiritual depiction of the village as referred to by Singh in the novel. The simple people in that hamlet don't know anything regarding the accelerated social and political changes that surround their village and hence they live as beehive helping and loving each other away of any considerations.

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However, the urgent and sudden changes taking place in the village begin to shift their minds to dealing seriously with them particularly after establishing the police station, the train station, and the arrival of the social worker into it. The wise people in the town start considering the impact of the current situations and yet they begin hearing some stories concerning the evacuation processes, evacuees, and the brutal episodes that are achieved behind the borders of both sides. Therefore, the purity of pastoral life in the town had been tragically shifted into later catastrophic sights.

It is true that, the adapted oeuvres may lose some parts as existed in the original text but what is more logical and significant is that, the filmic work after an adaptation and converting can confirm the indispensable and absolute theme of the original manuscript. So, Pandey and his fellow-actors could deftly carry on the main theme of *Train to Pakistan* particularly the process of evacuation and its surrounded ramifications. Moreover, no one can deny that, the directors of movies sometime centralize in unnecessary issues to be incarnated in the adapted films and hence such attention for highlighting recollected items in the text may lead to losing some necessary episodes from the original manuscript. Khalid Alqadhi posits that,

These statements or facts may be considered as window to cinema contribution. Adaptation is indeed a rewriting of a story, which can't be a copy paste of the original. It's a subjective interpretation of the director, inspired by a text, and then crafting his film differently. He may insist on some passages of the story than others or expand a single move briefly described in a novel, to a three-shot sequence, with discontinuity between the shots, deliberately changing the pace and the perspectives. Directors may reproduce the context or time period of the novel, but they also may keep only the highlights of the story, its main events, and then make the events take place in another time period, adapting the narrative to another time outline instead of adapting the characters to the period time of the novel. These infinite possibilities are in fact the value added of cinematic methods and aesthetic, even if no one can deny the enthusiastic attachment of most of the adaptations to stick to the original layout, especially when it comes to the adaptation of classics. (45)

The trauma of evacuation really represents so gloomy atmosphere for the innocent civilians of the Indian subcontinent. *Train to Pakistan* (1956) doesn't strive to highlight certain protagonist as in the classic fictionalization but rather Mano Majra, the novel's milieu, is portrayed to be the chief hero as it is the nature facing brutality, partition, evacuation, hatred, and plundering. All the four sections of the novel revolve around the plight of evacuation and therefore, all the terrible figures come into stage and minds under the influence of that calamity. The novel addresses also the geographical identity on basis of its religious dimensions that though the village is governed by Sikhs but a lot of Muslims and Hindus are residing on. The head constable extremely divides the town into two halves, one for the Sikhs and another for Muslims as aware regarding the behind-borders' massacres between the two

creeds and for the purpose of getting rid or avoiding of any melancholic events between the two parts.

Pandey and his team succeeded to adapt the Singh's imagination concerning the train of death coming from Pakistan with the train of miracle coming from India. Singh asserted that the train of death arrived from Pakistan loaded with a lot of murdered civilians. Moreover, Singh and even Pandey referred to the endless endeavors of the officials of Mano Majra to conceal the brutal sights of corpses from the eyes of village's inhabitants. The view of the soldiers and constables while firing the corpses was encapsulating the real meaning of that heinous evacuation. Some civilians in the village were hiding themselves in far places to watch the soldiers while firing the dead bodies particularly after participating in collecting of very big quantities of wood and more kerosene for the same purpose. Thus, an official authority in Mano Majra was aiming to prevent any atrocious events between Sikhs and Muslims and by the end of the novel, it asked the Muslims to leave the village in order to escape any imminent actions.

Undeniably the cinematographer often shelters to use some pictorial devices to unfold the concealed extensions of the fictionalized. Hence, Pandey and Brooks could brilliantly visualize the hidden lover (Juggut Singh) while climbing the ladder to cut off the robe of death for the purpose of rescuing the innocent civilians crowded in the train going to Pakistan. Therefore, the actors marvelously tried to visualize such sight and heroism of Singh in their film. George Bluestone asserts that,

On the one hand that phrase "to make you see" assumes an affective relationship between the creative artist and the receptive audience. Novelist and director meet here in common intention. One may, on the other hand, see visually through the eye or imaginatively through the mind. And between the percept of the visual image and the concept of the mental image lies the root difference between the two media. (1)

One of the most complex restrictions, Pandey and Brook faced, was the game of cinematic color due to the lore of Singh's Mano Majra. Unquestionably, coloring the items and components of any literary feat is not that easy duty to be achieved. Therefore, most of the movies makers and theatre directors try their best to imitate the real color described in the text but no one of them can escape the personal deviation in such decisive task. So, we can say that, the challenges of colorization in the film of *Train to Pakistan* is absolutely related into two dimensions. The first one is patently represented in the colorful videoing for the long shot of bloated human bodies floating down the swollen river watched by numbed inhabitants of Mano Majra in moonlight, and the second is the last scene of the film, with the train heading for Pakistan without any lights in a dark night. Thus, Brooks attempted well to convey similar visualization for the written one in the novel. Though it doesn't entirely close to that found in the fiction, but it incarnates very clear pictographic imagination for the spectators.

Train to Pakistan (1956) doesn't involve the women in reasoning of brutal and violent predicaments and such method can explicitly assert the inner atmosphere of Khushwant Singh towards the female gender. He believes that, the woman doesn't cause any kind of dilemmas for her society and yet she usually falls as a victim under the strict supremacy of patriarchy. So, Pandey and Brooks seem careful in their film of *Train to Pakistan* to depict the same imaginative feeling on the faces of Nooran and Haseena and even the dead bodies of the murdered women floating in the river. The women, according to *Train to Pakistan*, look like subjects for being abducted or kidnapped, raped, killed and illegally exploited. However, the woman is portrayed in very immoral appearance in the play as in the case of Haseena who shifts to be a prostitute. Kalpana Nehere and Pandurang Bhabad evaluate the position of the woman as very humiliated being. They retrieve the oppression of the woman during an evacuation saying,

Women in *Mano Majra* are projected in a sense of patriarchy. They are more passive, obedient and dependant for all kind of activities and busy in domestic unpaid works like cooking, cleaning, washing, rubbing, etc. They discussing about their emotional issues like births, marriages and deaths. These qualities are inculcated in girls from the early childhood through their play, customs, traditions, etc. The girls play safe game under the trees ... Women weaknesses and victims are presented with glorious manner in the name of nobility. Women and girls are victimized for revenge in communal violence. The rumors contain information of spoiled mothers, sisters and daughters. In all these situations of violence promoted and maintained by men and women are remain silent. Women follow the men. (Nehere and Bahadab 396).

To centralize certain concept in the cinematic adaptation is indubitably more difficult than the depiction of the same concept in the written feat because the pictographic idea reflects the team work whereas in the other dimension, the written one confirms an individual vision. The film in such thread, constitutes more clear visualization as it should expose every single item. So, the film director should deal with several instruments and frames as camera sound recording machine, lights, darkness, colors of the sky in the different views sights of day, and in the another extent with human beings and the location (Pasari 596). Thus, visualization seems different from actor to another and from theatre into another.

Conclusion:

Train to Pakistan, both as a manuscript and as a film, proves that the chaos of evacuation is tremendously regarded as one of the biggest exodus in the world during the twentieth century. Both Singh and Brooks strained the political and social aspects of the novel for the purpose of conveying the real face for the partition of the Indian subcontinent into India and Pakistan immediately after the independence. Hence, Singh succeeded in the creating of the concept launching from very human thought and Brooks smartly could convert such concept into the cinematographic world conveying the real picture of such catastrophe. Thus, the

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essential adaptation of *Train to Pakistan* into such graphic milieu is regarded as a great achievement as it could visualize the suffering of the innocent civilians, the jealousy of the British empire against both India and Pakistan, the triumph of love over hatred, the nobility of sacrificing and the tragic thread of evacuation.

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